

NEWSLETTER

March 2025

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CELEBRATING INNOVATION ACROSS KERALA: THE ENTE KERALAM JOURNEY WITH KSUM

As the Kerala Government marks four years of development and inclusive growth, the 'Ente Keralam' exhibition series has emerged as a powerful platform to showcase the state's strides in governance, technology, and innovation. Traveling across districts from Kasaragod to Trivandrum, the series has brought the vision of a future-ready Kerala directly to the people.

At the heart of this celebration stands the Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM), whose stall has consistently drawn attention for its immersive and inspiring displays. From futuristic healthtech to edtech marvels, the KSUM pavilion has turned into a hub of curiosity and conversation. One of the key attractions is IRIS, India's first AI-powered teacher robot, developed by Makerlabs with KSUM support, which is engaging children in a hands-on experience of the classrooms of tomorrow. Visitors have also had the chance to witness 3D bio-printing in action, learn about agri-drones by Fuselage Innovations, and interact with drone education kits designed especially for young learners. These innovations are not just exhibits—they are live examples of how Kerala's startup ecosystem is solving real-world problems through accessible technology. KSUM was honoured with the Excellence in Theme Stall award in Kottayam. The recognition reflects not only the quality of the exhibit but the growing impact and visibility of Kerala's startup community.

With each district, Ente Keralam is weaving a story of transformation, powered by vision, technology, and the collective will to build a smarter, more inclusive Kerala.



MEETING BETWEEN KERALA STARTUP MISSION MINISTRY OF SKILL DEVELOPMENT AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP (MSDE), GOVT OF KERALA, AND KERALA ACADEMY FOR SKILLS EXCELLENCE (KASE)

Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) recently convened a strategic meeting with the Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), Govt of Kerala, and Kerala Academy for Skills Excellence (KASE) to explore joint initiatives in skill development and innovation-led entrepreneurship.

The discussions brought together key stakeholders including Atul Kumar Tiwari IAS (Secretary, MSDE, Government of India), K Vasuki IAS (Secretary, Labour and Skills,



Government of Kerala), Sufiyan Ahmed IAS (Managing Director, KASE), Anoop Ambika (CEO, KSUM), Vinod T V (COO, KASE), Yuvraj C (Regional Director i/c, RDSDE), Manish Gupta (Deputy Director, MSDE), Ashok Kurian Panjikkaran, and Adithya S V. The meeting also focused on strengthening industry-academia linkages and building scalable, impactful programs for Kerala's youth.



KERALA STARTUP MISSION AND KOTAK MAHINDRA BANK MOU

Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) and Kotak Mahindra Bank have signed an MoU, focusing on key sectors like agriculture, medtech, electronics, and space. This collaboration will open new avenues for startups by providing essential financial support, mentorship, and global market access.

As part of this partnership, Kotak Mahindra Bank will offer expert guidance on regulatory compliance, export earnings, and fundraising, along with exclusive masterclasses and advisory sessions. Startups will also benefit



from Kotak's global network, connecting them with NRIs in Dubai, UK, and Singapore to explore international opportunities.



04

FOUNDERS MEET

The 27th edition of the Founders Meet, organized by Kerala Startup Mission, was successfully held on 28 April 2025 at UL Cyberpark, Calicut, uniting a vibrant mix of entrepreneurs, innovators, and ecosystem enablers from across Kerala. The event featured engaging sessions led by distinguished speakers including Allen Rintoul (CEO, Vonnue), Divya T (Co-founder, Zwayam), and Jabir Karat (Co-founder, Green Worms), who shared deep insights on startup challenges, innovation dynamics, and strategic growth. Founders Meet continues to be a cornerstone event for networking, knowledge exchange, and collaboration, playing a key role in strengthening Kerala's entrepreneurial landscape and fostering a culture of innovation.



05

INVESTOR CAFE

The Kochi edition of Investor Café, held at Kerala Startup Mission, brought together high-potential startups and leading investors for a focused day of pitching, expert insights, and meaningful networking.

Startups had the opportunity to present their ideas, receive valuable feedback, and explore funding opportunities. Investors engaged directly with innovative ventures from Kerala's growing startup ecosystem.

We extend our sincere thanks to our distinguished investor panel—Vishesh Rajaram (Speciale Invest), Mayuresh Raut (Sea Fund), Anil Joshi (Unicorn India Ventures), Preetham Naik (100Unicorns), Radhav Tandon (Pontaq VC), and Swarup Ravichandran (Tagalong VC)—for their presence and invaluable contributions.

KSUM remains committed to strengthening investor-startup connections and fostering a robust innovation ecosystem through initiatives like Investor Café.



06

STARTUP 360

Startup 360 – Trivandrum Edition was held on 30 April 2025 at Technopark, Thiruvananthapuram, bringing together early-stage entrepreneurs, domain experts, and ecosystem enablers for an engaging and insightful session. The event focused on practical learning and start-up readiness, offering tailored guidance through expert-led sessions on business planning, investor pitching, funding preparedness, financial compliance, and intellectual property essentials. Notable speakers included Brajesh Kaimal (Member, Malabar Angel Network), Rath-eesh C.K (Company Secretary & Financial Expert), Adv. Anusha Riyas (Senior IP Attorney, Puthran & Associates), and Vidya Prathap C (Patent Analyst, Puthran & Associates), who shared valuable insights and actionable advice.



07

KSUM DELEGATION AT MAHAKUMBH

A vibrant delegation of startups supported by Kerala Startup Mission (KSUM) successfully participated in Startup Mahakumbh 2025, held from April 3–5 at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi.

Throughout the three-day summit, KSUM-groomed startups actively engaged in discussions, mentorship sessions, and pitch presentations, showcasing their solutions to investors, industry leaders, and policy-makers. Several participating startups also



received promising investment opportunities and partnership leads during the event.

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CFO ROUNDTABLE 2025

CFO Roundtable 2025 concluded successfully on April 25 at O by Tamara, Thiruvananthapuram. Organized by HSBC in partnership with Kerala IT and Kerala Startup Mission, the event brought together leading finance professionals for in-depth discussions on macroeconomic trends, financial market outlook, trade finance, and liquidity management. Key insights were shared on global economic impacts, currency market strategies, and the role of digitization in finance. Participants walked away with actionable strategies and best practices to navigate financial uncertainties and drive strategic financial planning.

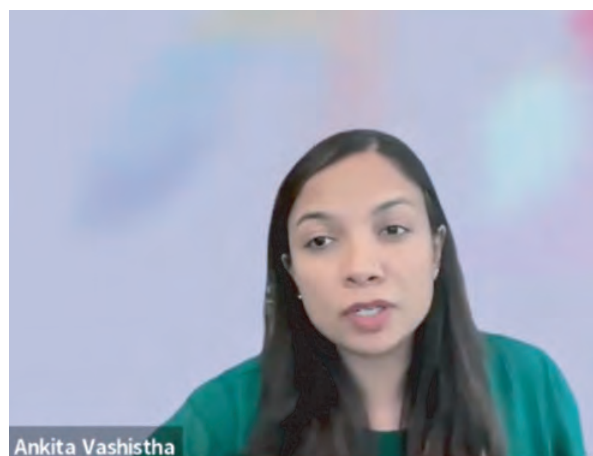


09

LEADER TALK WITH ANKITA VASHISTHA

The exclusive LeadHER Talk with Ankita Vashistha, Founder & Managing Partner of Arise Ventures, explored The Power of Diversity in Startup Investments. As a pioneer in venture capital, Ankita shared insights on fundraising challenges for women-led startups, purpose-driven business models, and balancing financial returns with social impact. She also highlighted key sectors for inclusive growth and strategies for startups to scale globally.

Her message to Kerala's startups was clear, think big, embrace technology, and build businesses that drive both profitability and impact.



The latest edition of InsightsXchange, at KSUM Kochi, brought together aspiring entrepreneurs, startup founders, and ecosystem enablers for a powerful session titled “Building & Funding Startups - The Kerala Playbook.” The event featured Mr. Anuroop V., Manager (Credit, MSME) at Bank of Baroda, and Mr. R. Roshan, acclaimed business journalist and author of ‘God’s Own Entrepreneurs’. The session included an engaging Q&A and networking interaction, sparking meaningful conversations around funding challenges and growth strategies. The event successfully empowered participants with practical insights on financing, policy support, and building impactful startups in Kerala.



The Innovation Tour held, at the KSUM Kochi campus, witnessed an overwhelming response, turning into a full house event packed with aspiring entrepreneurs, students, and innovators. The monthly event provided an immersive introduction to the growing startup ecosystem in Kerala. Participants explored the campus, learned about schemes, funding programs, incubation opportunities, and the overall support system by KSUM.



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FAB LAB VISIT

Glimpse from industrial visit at Fab Lab Thiruvananthapuram visit by , students and faculty from Mar Baselios College of Engineering and Technology. Fab Lab officials guided them through the facility, showcasing the advanced equipment and technologies available.



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AWS STARTUP DAY

AWS Startup Day successfully wrapped up at Kerala Startup Mission, Trivandrum and Calicut on April 24 and 25, 2025. The event brought together AWS experts, startup founders, and tech leaders for a day filled with deep dives into cloud technologies, GenAI, and GTM strategies. Startups gained exclusive insights, unlocked up to \$5000 in AWS credits, and benefited from free managed services and one-on-one expert sessions



Technical Committee Evaluation

The Startup Procurement Technical Committee conducted a meeting in the month of April to evaluate the following projects

SI No	Name of the Department	Requirement	Startup	Amount Approved (in Lakhs)
01	Kerala State IT Infrastructure Limited	Construction Project Management System (CPMS)	CloudHouse Technologies Private Limited	11.4
02	Department of Cooperative	Member Relief Fund Disbursal System	Collaborative Learning Labs Private Limited	4.42
03	AC Shanmugadas Memorial Ayurvedic Child & Adolescent Care Center, a unit under the District Ayurveda Hospital, Kozhikode	Auticare Virtual Therapy Unit	Embright Infotech Private Limited	9.9
04	Govt Model Boys Higher Secondary School	Implementation of Smart Lab	Alpha Classrooms	23.28

APRIL

No of EOIs	05
Project Under Evaluation	08
Projects Approved	03
Value of work orders(in Lakhs)	49
Active EOIs	0

MENTORSHIP STATS

37	INTERACTION
25	STARTUPS
27	MENTORS

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Have a thought, comment or suggestion to share with us?

We'd love to hear from you.
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